

Course of Action

COMPLETE LEARNING GUIDE

What You'll Learn

Course of action questions present a problem or situation and one or more numbered suggested actions, asking which action(s) would be a sensible, practical, and feasible step toward addressing that specific problem — not toward some broader or ideal goal. Unlike conclusion questions (which ask what logically FOLLOWS from a statement), course of action questions ask what should be DONE, and the correct answer must satisfy two independent tests: it must follow reasonably from the problem as stated, and it must be practically implementable/administratively feasible, not merely a nice-sounding aspiration. This sub-module covers the two-part sufficiency test (relevance + feasibility), distinguishing a real course of action from a vague suggestion or a restatement of the problem, handling multi-action (I and II) questions, common patterns in administrative/policy problems, and the classic trap of overly extreme or disproportionate actions.

1. The Two-Part Test: Relevance and Feasibility

A valid course of action must pass BOTH tests: (1) it addresses the specific problem described — not a different, related problem — and (2) it is practically implementable with reasonably available means, not something vague, extreme, or requiring resources/authority the situation doesn't establish exist.

- Problem: 'Absenteeism among factory workers has risen sharply in the last quarter.' Action: 'The factory should investigate the reasons for increased absenteeism and address the root causes.' This passes both tests — it directly targets the stated problem and is a standard, implementable administrative step. A failing alternative: 'The factory should shut down operations' — this is feasible in principle but wildly disproportionate to the stated problem (relevance test fails, since it doesn't sensibly address absenteeism specifically).

2. Distinguishing a Real Action From a Restatement

A common wrong-answer trap simply restates the problem in imperative form ('the problem should be solved') without specifying any actual step — this fails the test because it provides no genuine course of action, just a hope that the problem goes away.

- Problem: 'Sales in the northern region have dropped by 30% this quarter.' Weak non-action: 'Sales in the northern region should improve.' (This just restates the desired outcome, not a step to achieve it.) Valid action: 'The company should conduct a market survey in the northern region to identify the cause of the sales decline.' (This specifies an actual, implementable step.)

3. Multi-Action (I and II) Questions

When two numbered actions are given, apply the two-part test to each INDEPENDENTLY — it's common for both to be individually valid non-conflicting steps (answer: both follow), for only one to be proportionate, or for the two to be mutually exclusive alternatives (in which case 'either I or II' may be the intended answer if the problem doesn't favor one over the other).

- Problem: 'A bridge has developed cracks and is unsafe for heavy vehicles.' Action I: 'Heavy vehicles should be barred from using the bridge until repairs are completed.' Action II: 'The bridge should be immediately repaired by a structural engineering team.' Both are relevant and feasible, and they aren't mutually exclusive (one is an immediate safety measure, the other a fix) — both actions follow.

4. Common Patterns in Administrative/Policy Problems

Government and institutional 'course of action' problems frequently have a standard correct-answer shape: investigate the cause, take a proportionate corrective/preventive administrative step, or enforce an existing rule more strictly — actions that call for something outside the administration's typical authority (declaring an emergency, changing a law unilaterally) are usually distractors.

- Problem: 'Several students have been caught copying in the final exams this year.' Reasonable action: 'The examination authority should tighten invigilation and enforce stricter anti-copying measures in future exams.' Disproportionate distractor: 'All exams for the affected batch should be cancelled permanently' — too extreme and not a measured administrative response to the stated problem.

5. The Trap of Overly Extreme or Disproportionate Actions

An action that would technically 'solve' the problem but at a wildly disproportionate cost, or that addresses a much broader issue than what was actually described, should be rejected — course of action questions specifically test whether a candidate can judge PROPORTIONALITY, not just logical connection to the topic.

- Problem: 'A single employee has been consistently arriving late this month.' Disproportionate action: 'The company should revise its attendance policy for all employees.' Proportionate action: 'The manager should discuss the lateness directly with that employee and understand the reason.' The disproportionate option treats an individual issue as an organization-wide one.

6. Actions Requiring Unstated Authority or Resources

Reject an action that assumes a level of authority, budget, or resource availability the passage never establishes — a locally-scoped problem (one school, one branch office) shouldn't be 'solved' by an action that requires national policy change or resources clearly beyond that scope, unless the statement explicitly grants that authority.

- Problem: 'One particular branch of a bank has been receiving frequent customer complaints about long queues.' Action within scope: 'That branch should add an additional counter during peak hours.' Action outside scope: 'The bank should redesign its national branch network' — this exceeds what a single branch's queue problem calls for or what the passage's stated authority (branch-level) can act on.

Common Pitfalls

- Selecting an action that would technically fix the problem but is wildly disproportionate in scale or cost to what was actually described.
- Accepting a restated version of the desired outcome ('the problem should be solved') as if it were an actual, specific course of action.
- Choosing an action that requires authority, budget, or resources the passage never establishes as available at the stated level (branch, individual, department).
- Judging relevance alone without separately checking feasibility, or vice versa — both tests must pass independently.
- Treating an individual-level problem (one employee, one incident) as requiring an organization-wide policy action.
- In multi-action (I/II) questions, assuming the two actions are automatically mutually exclusive when they may both be valid, complementary steps.
- Selecting an action addressing a broader or different problem than the one specifically described in the passage.

Key Takeaways

- A valid course of action must pass two independent tests: relevance to the SPECIFIC stated problem, and practical feasibility.
- Reject actions that merely restate the desired outcome without specifying an actual, implementable step.
- Reject disproportionate actions — the scale of the response should match the scale of the problem as described.
- Reject actions requiring authority or resources beyond what the passage establishes exists at the relevant level.
- In multi-action questions, test each action independently; both can validly follow if they're relevant, feasible, and non-conflicting.
- Standard administrative course-of-action answers usually mean investigate the cause, take a proportionate corrective step, or better enforce an existing rule.

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